

# ZHIYUAN LAI

Ph.D. Applicant (Fall 2027) | Peking University

Research interests: information practices, social justice, digital inequality, and human-centered AI

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## EDUCATION

**Peking University**, Beijing, China

B.Mgt. in Information Management and Information Systems

Sep 2023 – Jun 2027 (expected)

B.A. in Sociology (Double Major)

Sep 2025 – Jun 2027 (expected)

GPA: 3.72/4.00; Rank: 7/82

**National Tsing Hua University**, Taiwan | Visiting Student

Jul 2025 – Aug 2025

## PUBLICATIONS

### Peer-reviewed publications

**Lai, Z.**, Liang, X., Jiang, C., & Li, Z. Lives of the infamous: Identity linkage potential and everyday information practices among people living with HIV. *ACM/IEEE-CS Joint Conference on Digital Libraries (JCDL) 2026*, Accepted.

**Lai, Z.**, & Tang, Y. (2026). Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 328-344.  
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64121>.

Chen, N., **Lai, Z.**, Liu, Y., Li, J., Wang, R., & Yan, P. (2026). See, trust, and interact: How AI disclosure shapes high school students' trust. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 1099-1145.  
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64165>.

### Working Papers

Tang, Y., & **Lai, Z.** Empowering LGBTQIA+ identity formation in China through LLM-based chatbots. *Journal of Information Science*, Under Review.

**Lai, Z.**, Ran, W., Chen, Z., & Yan, P. Public trust in generative AI in China: A mixed-methods scale development and validation study. Manuscript in preparation for submission to *Telematics & Informatics*.

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE & SELECTED PROJECTS

**33<sup>rd</sup> Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition (First Prize)** Nov 2024 – Mar 2025

*Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms* Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Integrated ethnographic fieldwork in Langfang, Hebei (semi-structured interviews with 20 participants) and computational analysis from Douyin and Kuaishou (BERTopic for 19,193 public comments) to demonstrate how short-video practices enable middle-aged and older rural women to negotiate social marginalization, construct online identities, and sustain community ties.

**34<sup>th</sup> Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition (Third Prize)** Nov 2025 – Mar 2026

*Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV — Information Practices as a Survival Strategy* Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Developed an inductive analytical framework based on multi-site fieldwork at Beijing Ditan Hospital and the Beijing Red Ribbon Home (22 semi-structured interviews, 32 hours of field observation, 2 months of online ethnography on RedNote), showing how people living with HIV regulate information disclosure, navigate identity-linking information flows, and convert information into sustainable everyday practices under conditions of stigma.

**Undergraduate Research Program, Leader (Selected as Excellent Project)**

May 2024 – Oct 2025

*Public Trust and Attitudes toward Generative AI in China*

Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan

(Selected as an Excellent Undergraduate Research Project)

- Led a multi-stage mixed-methods study, including developing an original scale of Trust in GenAI, validating the scale across two survey studies (N = 455 and 479) and designing a between-subject eye-tracking experiment (N=60) to examine how different AI disclosure strategies influence users' trust across different platform contexts.

**Research Assistant, National Natural Science Foundation of China (Young Scientists Fund) May 2024–Present**

*A Study on the Influencing Factors and Mechanisms of the Algorithmic Divide.*

PI: Dr. Pu Yan

- Conducted literature reviews on the algorithmic divide and digital inequality, and analyzed survey data from 662 respondents using regression analysis with R to examine factors associated with algorithmic awareness, digital access, and social media use.

**Research Assistant, Beijing Social Science Fund (General Project)**

May 2024–Present

*A Study on Algorithm Literacy among Beijing Citizens*

PI: Dr. Pu Yan

- Refine and pilot-test survey instruments for measuring algorithm literacy across demographic groups. Designed and conducted an eye-tracking experiment in Beijing to examine users' visual attention and behavioral responses to algorithmically curated content on social media platforms.

## CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

**iConference 2026**

Edinburgh, Scotland, UK | Mar 2026

Full Paper Presentation: “Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use.”

**Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2026**

Xi'an, China | Jul 2026

Poster Presentation: “Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV.”

**19th National Doctoral Forum in Library and Information Science**

Beijing, China | May 2026

Research Presentation: “The Lives of the Infamous: Information Practices as a Survival Strategy for PLHIV.”

**Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2025**

Chengdu, China | Jul 2025

Full Paper Presentation: “Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms.”

## TEACHING & MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Qualitative Data Analysis, Peking University

Fall 2026

Teaching Assistant, AI Literacy Summer Camp, Fucheng Aidi Junior High School, Shandong

Summer 2026

First-Year Peer Advisor for the 2025 & 2026 Incoming Cohort, Peking University

Aug 2025 – Present

## HONORS & AWARDS

National Scholarship; Model Merit Student (Top 2% University-Wide)

2025 – 2026

First Prize, 33rd Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition (University-Level)

2025

Excellent Undergraduate Research Project, Peking University Undergraduate Research Program

2025

Merit Student; National Encouragement Scholarship; Second-Class Scholarship

2024 – 2025

Award for Academic Excellence; National Encouragement Scholarship

2023 – 2024

## METHODOLOGICAL EXPERTISE

**Qualitative Research**

Interviews, participant observation, online ethnography

**Survey Research**

Survey design, scale development and validation, psychometric analysis

**Experimental Research**

Experimental design, eye tracking, behavioral data analysis

**Computational Social Science**

Web scraping, topic modeling, text analysis

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

**Data Analytics & Programming**

Python, R, Stata, SPSS, NVivo, SQL

**Web Technologies**

JavaScript, HTML, CSS

**Languages**

English (TOEFL iBT: 104), Chinese (native), Hakka (native)